

ENVISION GREATNESS · BRITTANY CLAUSEN

THE REAL WORK

A Journal for Visionaries Who Feel the Pull

Five reflections to help you stop circling the same patterns and start rising from the inside out.

by Brittany Clausen, MSW

This isn't a quiz. There's no score.

What you're holding is a set of questions I wish someone had handed me earlier — the kind that cut through the résumé, the hustle, and the performance, and get to what's actually running the show.

There are five themes. Each one has three prompts. They're not easy. They're not supposed to be.

Write whatever comes up first. The unfiltered version — the one you wouldn't say out loud in a meeting or on a call. That's the version that's actually true. And that's the version that changes something.

You don't have to finish in one sitting. Come back to it. Some of these will land differently on different days. That's the point.

The only rule: no performance. Not here.

"The gap isn't what you know. It's what you're not yet willing to look at."

PART ONE OF FIVE

The Gap

The space between who you know you are and who actually shows up.

"Everyone I've ever worked with has this gap. The ones who grow fastest aren't the ones with the smallest gap — they're the ones brave enough to name it."

You know who you want to be. Who actually shows up?

We all carry a version of ourselves we believe is the real one — the patient one, the clear-headed one, the person who handles hard things with grace. And then there's the version that shows up when we're stressed, challenged, or afraid. This section is about getting honest about that gap.

Describe the person you believe you are. Then describe who shows up for others when you're under pressure. Where does the story break down?

Don't narrate this from the outside in. Start with: 'I know I'm at my worst when...'

PROMPT 2 OF 3

What's the version of yourself you're most afraid people will see — in your work, your business, your relationships? When does that version come out?

The things we're most afraid of being seen doing — we're usually already doing them.

PROMPT 3 OF 3

What would change — right now, this week — if you closed the gap between who you believe you are and how you actually show up?

This isn't hypothetical. Pick one specific relationship or situation.

Before you move on: What did you notice about yourself while answering these?

The Pattern

What keeps showing up, no matter how many times you change the cast.

"Your patterns don't come from nowhere. They were once the smartest, safest thing you could do. They just didn't get the memo that you've grown."

The same dynamic keeps showing up. Why?

Different job. Different team. Different city. Same problem. If the situation keeps changing but the friction stays the same — a pattern is running the show. Patterns aren't weaknesses. They're old strategies. The question is: are they still working for you — or against you?

PROMPT 1 OF 3

What's a conflict or frustration that has shown up repeatedly in your work or personal life — with different people, but the same basic feeling? Describe it.

Don't analyze it yet. Just describe what it feels like when it happens.

PROMPT 2 OF 3

What do you typically do when conflict or tension shows up? Do you move toward it, away from it, or manage it by controlling the outcome?

Be honest. Most of us have a default move we've been using since long before our current role.

PROMPT 3 OF 3

If the pattern you described started as a way to protect yourself — what were you protecting yourself from? What's it costing you now?

This is the one that changes things. Don't rush it.

Before you move on: Name the pattern in one sentence. Just one.

PART THREE OF FIVE

The Trigger

What sets you off — and what it's actually about underneath.

"A trigger isn't a flaw. It's a clue. Every time something gets under your skin more than it should, it's pointing to something that still needs your attention."

What gets under your skin — and what is it really about?

Triggers are not weaknesses. They're information. The person who has 'no triggers' has simply gotten very good at suppressing them — which means they leak out sideways in ways that are harder to see. Getting clear on your triggers is one of the highest-leverage moves you can make.

Think of the last time you reacted to something — at work, in your business, or at home — more intensely than the situation probably warranted. What happened?

The 'more than warranted' part is the tell. That's where the real information lives.

PROMPT 2 OF 3

What specific behaviors or situations tend to trigger your strongest reactions? Be specific — not 'people who are disrespectful' but exactly what disrespect looks like when it sets you off.

Vague triggers can't be managed. Specific ones can.

PROMPT 3 OF 3

Under the trigger — what's the deeper fear or wound it's connected to? What does this reaction say about what you need, or what you're afraid of losing?

This is hard. It's supposed to be. Take your time.



Before you move on: What would it look like to respond to that trigger instead of react?

The Story

The narrative that's driving everything — often from years ago.

"Most of us are still operating from a story we wrote about ourselves before we had any real power. Update the story — and you update everything."

What story about yourself are you still living from?

We all carry a core narrative — about who we are, what we're worth, what we're capable of, what we have to prove. That story usually got written in circumstances that had nothing to do with who you've become or the vision you're carrying. But it runs quietly in the background, influencing every decision, every relationship, every moment you pull back when you should step forward.

What's the story about yourself that quietly drives how hard you work, how much you need to achieve, or what you're afraid of losing?

Start with: 'If I'm honest, I'm still trying to prove that...'

PROMPT 2 OF 3

Where did that story come from? Who or what told you — directly or indirectly — that this was true about you?

You don't have to go deep into childhood. Sometimes it's a boss, a failure, a single moment.

PROMPT 3 OF 3

Is that story still true? Or is it something you inherited that you've never questioned? What would you tell someone you loved if they were living by that same story?

You already know the answer. The question is whether you'll let it land.

Before you move on: Write one sentence starting with 'The truth is...'

The Move

Not someday. Not when things calm down. Right now.

"I've never met someone who didn't already know what they needed to do. What they needed was the courage to stop waiting for the perfect moment to do it."

You already know. What are you waiting for?

The inner work is not a destination. It's a practice. But at some point, the reflection has to translate into something — a conversation you've been avoiding, a boundary you've been soft about, a vision you've been shrinking yourself to fit. This last section is about that.

PROMPT 1 OF 3

Based on everything you've written — what's the one thing you've been most afraid to admit to yourself about how you're showing up right now?

Not your team. Not your business. Not your family. You.

PROMPT 2 OF 3

What's one specific relationship, conversation, or dynamic in your life that would shift if you applied even a fraction of what came up in this journal?

Be specific. Name the person. Name the thing. Vagueness is how we stay stuck.

PROMPT 3 OF 3

What's one thing you will do differently — this week, not someday — as a direct result of what you discovered here?

Write it as a commitment. Not 'I'll try to...' — 'I will...'

You just did the work that most people never do. That matters.

WHAT COMES NEXT

The insight is just the beginning. Now it has to go somewhere.

What you uncovered in this journal doesn't have to stay in these pages. This is the work I do with driven women and professionals every day — helping them take what they've seen about themselves and build something better with it. In their businesses. In their relationships. In the way they show up when it matters.

If something landed for you, let's talk about what's next.

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